

Common Name: Laughing Gull **Scientific Name:** *Larus atricilla*
Number of Individuals: 1 **Sex:** ? **Age:** first-alternate
Locality: **Colorado:** John Martin Reservoir, BENT **County**
Date(s) Seen: 7 July 2000 **Time:** 15:35
Reporting Observer: Christopher L. Wood, 3465 S. Otis Court, Lakewood, CO 80227
Other Observers: None.
Conditions: 35 mph wind, 99 degrees F. **Optical Equipment:** Leica APO Televid scope, 32x wide.
Distance to Bird: 200 - 500 meters
Duration of Observation: about 1 minute.
Habitat: In flight over John Martin Reservoir

7-0(A)
Rcd 2/19/01 WPE

Description:

While scanning through a mixed flock of Franklin's and California gulls standing on a small peninsula west of "Finger Island," I noticed a long-winged, dark-headed gull flying a few hundred meters from shore. The bird flew into the strong winds, mostly gliding and arcing, sometimes with stiff, and relatively shallow wingbeats. The flight style was a dead-ringer for Laughing Gull (reminiscent of a Parasitic Jaeger), and very different from that of nearby Franklin's Gulls. The bird appeared longer in length and longer-winged than Franklin's Gulls, but had a slimmer, more angular and less dumpy, look.

The head and nape were dark; slightly darker behind the eye; lighter on the crown and throat. The upperparts were mostly gray (similar in color to an adult California Gull, but with more of a brown hue), contrasting with a whitish rump, which contrasted with a dark tail band. Underparts were whitish with darker flanks and breast band.

From above, the primaries, primary coverts and secondaries were very dark brown, slightly lighter on the inner primaries. The grayish brown secondary coverts contrasted conspicuously with the dark primaries. There was a very narrow white trailing edge to the secondaries and inner secondaries that was visible from above and below. From below, the primaries and secondaries were dark-brown black, darkest on the outer primaries, contrasting with the whitish underwing coverts.

The all dark bill was longer and slightly heavier than the nearby Franklin's Gulls.

Vocalizations:

None

Similar Species:

Franklin's Gull has a lighter underwing, more well-defined black on the head that contrasts with a whiter nape, is smaller, has less pointed wings, and looks dumpy. A Ring-billed Gull x Laughing Gull hybrid would show some Ring-billed Gull features, almost always (always?) including some pale on the base of the bill.

Tape recordings / Photos?

None

References:

None

Description from: __XX__ Contemporaneous notes; __ Later notes; __ Memory.

Experience with Species:

I have seen 10,000s of Laughing Gulls, and spent many hours studying them while serving as the official seabird counter for Cape May Bird Observatory at the Avalon Seawatch, NJ. I have also seen 10,000s of Franklin's Gulls, mostly in eastern Colorado, and all other likely gulls.

Are you Positive of the Identification? Yes.

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